Lesson 17: Critical Thinking Questions and Unit Review

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.11: Language Toolkit; 1.12: Takeaways.

In this lesson

You will learn five levels of critical thinking questions that prepare you for a discussion about a reading, identify the level of each question, and write your own questions. Then you will review the whole unit with the chapter's reflection questions. Discussions, in seminars and in online forums, are a central part of university courses, and good questions take the conversation below the surface of a text.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Name and explain five levels of questions: experiential, literal, interpretive, thematic and evaluative.
- Identify the level of a question about a text.
- Write questions at each level about a reading or a lecture.
- Lead a short discussion with your tutor using your own questions.
- Reflect on the Unit 2 reading strategies and choose the ones you will use more.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
critical thinking question	a question about the deeper levels of a text and the ideas behind it	Prepare questions that get at the deeper levels of the text.
experiential question	a question about the reader's own experience and feelings	Have you ever ...? How did you feel when ...?
literal question	a question with one correct answer, found directly in the text	Who is ...? What happens in this section?
interpretive question	a question about meaning between the lines; several answers, all based on the text	What is the significance of the title?
thematic question	a question about the message beyond the text and the bigger issues	How is X common in the real world?
evaluative question	a question that judges how well the text works	How effective is this paragraph?
between the lines	what a text suggests but does not say directly	These questions try to find the meaning between the lines.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
point of view	the author's position or attitude	What can we say about the author's point of view?
tone	the attitude a text shows through its words (serious, angry, hopeful)	What is the tone of this text?
objective	fair, not influenced by personal feelings	Does the author seem objective?
bias	a strong opinion that makes it hard to be objective	Does this part show bias for or against X?
quadruple	become four times as large	Why do you think immigration has quadrupled in the U.S. since 1960?

Rules and explanations

Why write discussion questions?

- Questions before, during and after reading (Lesson 12) help you think about a text and check your understanding.
- Discussion questions have another purpose: they prepare you for a discussion, in person or online, that goes below the surface, to the deeper levels of the text and the ideas behind it. Preparing questions at all five levels makes you look at different parts of the text and of your reading experience.

Five levels of questions

Level	What it asks	Answers	Question starters
Experiential	How does this make me feel? What does it remind me of?	many, from each reader's experience	Have you ever ...? Which part do you like? How did you feel when ...?
Literal	What does it say? What does this word, phrase or paragraph mean?	one correct answer, directly in the text	Who is ...? What happens in this section? What is the connection between X and Y?
Interpretive	What does it mean? What are the reasons for people's actions? How are the parts connected?	more than one, but based on the text	What can we say about the author's point of view? What is the significance of the title? What is the tone, purpose or audience?
Thematic	What is the message beyond this text? What bigger issues does it deal with?	many, found outside the text; the text is a starting place	How is X common in the real world? Why do people ...? What is the truth about ...?

Level	What it asks	Answers	Question starters
Evaluative	How effective is this paragraph, section or chapter? Why did the author make these choices, and how well do they work?	many, found outside the text, but referring to it	How does the author use X to show Y? How could this be better if ...? Does this part show bias for or against X?

- Literal or interpretive? Ask where the answer is. If the text states it directly, the question is literal; if you must work it out from clues in the text, it is interpretive.
- Thematic or evaluative? A thematic question moves from the text to the world; an evaluative question judges the text itself.

Unit 2 in one table

Skill	Lesson
Identify reading strategies; preview with the 4 Ps and KWL+; reading response journals	11
Read actively: questions before, during and after reading; annotation	12
Find the topic, main idea and supporting details; identify pathos, ethos and logos	13
Paraphrase and summarize	14
Choose quotations and analyze a text	15
Deal with unfamiliar vocabulary: context clues, word parts, reference tools	16
Ask critical thinking questions for discussion	17

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic can form a yes/no question by adding a question word to a normal statement, or by intonation alone. Formal English needs an auxiliary verb before the subject: "Does the author try to convince the reader ...?" (not "The author tries to convince the reader ...?").

Practice

Exercise 1. Identify the level of each question. These questions are about "Changes in U.S. Immigration Patterns and Attitudes" (Lesson 12 material, section 1.4). Decide which of the five levels each question represents: experiential, literal, interpretive, thematic or evaluative.

1. Why do you think immigration has quadrupled in the U.S. since 1960?
2. Which part of the reading did you find most surprising, and why?
3. What percentage of immigrants come from Mexico? What about Asia?
4. Does the author try to convince the reader to change policies toward undocumented immigrants, or does the author seem objective in their discussion regarding immigration patterns and attitudes?
5. Why do most U.S. citizens agree that immigration policies need to change? What might be the bigger issue here?

Exercise 2. Write your own questions. Prepare for a discussion of "Deport Me" by Alejandro Fuentes-Mena (Lesson 11 material). Write one question at each of the five levels. Then answer your literal question from the text.

Exercise 3. Questions for reflection. Answer each question in 2-3 sentences, then discuss your answers with your tutor. (In the material, questions 3 and 4 contain editing errors; they are corrected here.)

1. What is difficult about reading and responding to texts? How would you like to change your reading approach?
2. Which active reading strategies do you already use? Which would you like to try using more?
3. What kinds of questions do you usually ask before, during, and after reading a text? Is it most useful for you to just think these questions in your head, to write them down, or to discuss them with someone else?
4. How can you add your ideas when analyzing a text?
5. How are your strategies for learning new vocabulary different from just being able to read a text with unfamiliar vocabulary? Which words do you usually focus on learning, and which ones do you skip or just guess the meaning of?
6. Look back at the Sample Reading Response Journal (Lesson 11). Which of the techniques from this chapter did you use to read the text? What techniques does the writer use in their responses? How can reading responses help you to think more deeply about a reading and prepare for writing?

Speak with your tutor

- "Here are my five questions about 'Deport Me': [paste]. Tell me the level of each one. Then answer my interpretive question, and let me respond to your answer."
- "Lead a discussion with me about 'Changes in U.S. Immigration Patterns and Attitudes'. Ask me one question at each level, from experiential to evaluative."
- "Give me ten new questions about a PSYC 110 lecture. I will name the level of each one and explain why."
- "Quiz me on Unit 2: ask me to explain the 4 Ps, KWL+, the three rhetorical appeals, the rules for a paraphrase and the parts of a summary."
- "Ask me the reflection questions one by one. At the end, suggest two reading strategies I should practise more."

Read aloud

In WH-questions, the voice usually falls at the end; in yes/no questions, it usually rises; in an either-or question, it rises on the first choice and falls on the last.

1. Why do you think immigration has quadrupled in the U.S. since 1960? (falls)
2. Which part of the reading did you find most surprising, and why? (falls)

3. Does the author try to convince the reader to change policies, or does the author seem objective? (rises, then falls)
4. Have you ever felt that other people valued you less? (rises)
5. What can we say about the author's point of view? (falls)
6. Word stress: ex·pe·ri·EN·tial, LIT·er·al, in·TER·pre·tive, the·MAT·ic, e·VAL·u·a·tive.

Writing task

Discussion questions and a response. Choose one text: a reading from Unit 2 ("Deport Me", "The Dreamers", the Adelman and Reid article, the Nguyen editorial) or a psychology text, for example PSYC 110 Lecture 17, Chapter 3, "Positive Uses and Negative Effects of Stereotypes", or a section of the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e* (https://openstax.org/details/books/psychology-2e).

1. Write five discussion questions, one at each level, and label each level.
2. Write a response of 200-250 words to your interpretive, thematic or evaluative question. Use at least one short quotation and one paraphrase or summary from the text.

Checklist:

- Each question matches its level: literal questions have one answer in the text; thematic questions go beyond the text.
- Your questions have correct word order (auxiliary before the subject).
- The response begins with a clear answer to your question.
- The quotation is exact and introduced with the author's name and a reporting verb; the paraphrase is in your own words and structure.
- You explain the significance of your evidence, not only repeat it.
- You use the present tense for what the author writes.
- Your own ideas and the author's ideas are clearly separated.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Interpretive (book). The text gives the numbers (9.7 million immigrants in 1960, 44.8 million in 2018) but not the reasons, so the reader must read between the lines.
2. Experiential (book). It asks about the reader's own reaction.
3. Literal (book). The answer is in the text. Note that the text gives numbers, not percentages: in 2015, there were 11.6 million immigrants from Mexico and 12.1 million from South or East Asia.
4. Evaluative (book). It asks the reader to judge the text: is it persuasive or objective, and does it show bias?
5. Thematic (book). "The bigger issue" takes the discussion beyond the text, to the real world.

Exercise 2 (example answer)

- Experiential: Have you ever felt that other people valued you less because of where you came from?
- Literal: How much did his mother's employers promise to pay her for a weekend, and how much did she bring home? (Answer: over 300 dollars; only 100 dollars.)
- Interpretive: What is the significance of the title, "Deport Me"?
- Thematic: Why do people sometimes come to believe what society says about their worth?
- Evaluative: How does Fuentes-Mena use the form of a math lesson to show the value of undocumented people, and how well does it work?

Exercise 3

1. (example answer) Long texts with many new words are difficult, and I often read every word slowly. I want to preview first and read some parts quickly.
2. (example answer) I already preview titles and headings. I would like to annotate more, especially with questions and connections.
3. (example answer) I usually ask only literal questions in my head. Writing questions down, at different levels, helps me more.
4. (example answer) I can make connections to my own life, other texts and the world, and explain why a passage matters, while I keep the author's ideas and my ideas clearly separate.
5. (example answer) To read, I only need a rough meaning, so I guess from context. I study words that appear often or are important in my subject, such as psychology terms.
6. (example answer for the first and last parts) I used prereading and looked for the main idea. Reading responses make me choose important passages and explain them, so I already have quotations and ideas when I write. The writer's techniques (from the text): short, exact quotations introduced with the author's last name and a reporting verb (recalls, explains, writes, reports); paraphrase and summary; analysis of contrast, symbol, repetition, parallel structure, rhyme and sentence length; a personal connection (entry 4); square brackets and ellipses to fit quotations into sentences.

My notes